

Chapter II-THE CELTIC PERIOD

A. The "Celtic Period" designates those centuries during which Celtic culture and the Celtic type of Christianity (rather than Roman usages and organization) were dominant in Scotland.

Just who the Celts were and their exact origin is not certainly known. Including several racial types they were collectively called "Keltoi" by the Greeks, and "Celtae" by the Romans. Their best known descendants today are the Irish, Welsh and Gaelic Scots. The Celts likely were wanderers and centuries before the Christian era, some came into Ireland from continental Europe and settled. Some of these were called "Scots", and for centuries Ireland was known as "Scotia" to Northern European tribes.

Under this new group there grew up in the northeastern part of Ireland a new culture that was considered superior to that of northern Europe. In religion the most zealous missionary and efficient organizer was Patrick, later patron saint of Ireland.

Patrick was really a native of Scotland, born of Christian parents on the river Clyde, near Glasgow. After he came to Ireland, the local Christianity became systematized and made rapid progress. This ancient Christianity seems not to have had much contact with papal Rome. Its usages were more those of the Eastern Church, which had come to Ireland by way of the Gallic Church, which traces to Asia Minor by way of Irenaeus of Lyons.

St. Patrick's organization was of the monastic type. Walker [60] says, "It seems certain that Patrick introduced the diocesan system into Ireland, but that system was soon modified by the Clan system of the Island, so that there were many monastic and tribal bishops." Thus the office of bishops might often have been filled by appointment within the tribe or monastery. A group of monasteries grew up which became famous for their learning all over Europe during the 6th and 7th centuries, but the chief glory of this Irish monasticism was its missionary zeal.

B. The Kingdom of Dalriada. The beginning of Celtic influence in Scotland was 503 AD, when some Scots migrated from northern Ireland into the district on the west coast of Scotland now known as Argyll. Their leader was Fergus mac Erc, a descendant of Conor II, High King of Ireland. With Fergus were his brothers, Loarn and Angus. The 3 brothers divided the territory between them and their settlement grew rapidly. Having come from the district of Dalriads in Ireland, they called their new kingdom Dalriada and became known as the Dalriadic Scots of Albany.

There were now 3 kingdoms in northern Britain: the Kingdoms of the Northern Picts and of the Southern Picts and the Kingdom of the Scots, Dalriada, on the west. Before leaving Ireland the Scots had been converted, at least to some depth, to Christianity by St. Patrick's mission. The Picts were likely Druids and of a lower level culturally. They had a reputation of fierceness in battle and painted their faces before going into battle, either to identify one another or to add to their frightening aspect.

Skene[52] assigned a very early origin to the MacGregors, MacNaughtons, MacPhies, MacKinnons & MacQuarries, holding that all were descended from Ferchar, King of Dalriada, through Ferchar Fada (Farquhar the Tall).

C. The Beginings of Christianity in Scotland. Christianity came to Scotland very early, probably carried by refugees from the Continent. Only a few heroic missionaries are know to us today. They worked individually with little support from other churches.

St. Ninian still has his name associated with some churches, wells and other sacred spots[Kilninian(Church of Ninian), still standing on the Isle of Mull, was the parish church of Clan Mac-Quarrie for many years]. After a residence in Rome he came to Scotland about 390 AD where, according to Bede, he preached to the Picts and built a small church which was later replaced by an Abbey who ruins may still be seen. His work did made little lasting impression, since he came to Scotland more than a century before the founding of Dalriada.

About 100 years later St. Kentigern(or Mungo) became Bishop of the area where St. Ninian had worked. He was opposed by pagan King Morken and forced to leave, but after the Christian victory at Ardderyd(573) he returned to Glasgow. Columba, while preaching near the river Tay in 584, probable meet Kentigern.

Columba(521-597), shining light of Celtic Christian missions, had come from Ireland to Scotland in 563. In Scotland he found a Christian king and people in Dalriada. He was given the Isle of Iona(then called "I") for home and missionary headquarters. On I they built a church, monastery and training school. "This monastery was on the northeast shore, probably on a Druid temple site, where the medieval Abbey stands, and it grew to be a community of about 150 white-robed monks, saints and scholars."[50].

Columba and his friends went through all northern Scotland and within a few years established scores of churches. They endured all kinds of hardships and dangers from stormy weather to violent attacks by half-savage natives who were stirred up by Druid priests. On the other hand, sometimes the conversion of a Druid leader would bring about the mass conversion of his followers.

One such case was that of Brude, King of the Picts who turned from Druidism to Christianity because of a miracle performed by St. Columba. How deep such conversions were may be questioned, but they were not rare occurrences. It is probable that St. Oran was once a prominent Druid. The rapid conversion of Druid leaders would partly account for the phenomenal progress, in so short a time, that Christianity made throughout northern Scotland.

After more than 30 years among the poor, sick and heathen of Scotland, St. Columba died in Iona in 597; the same year in which the Roman monk, St Augustine, landed in southern England to begin his missionary work among the Saxons.

Semple[50] writes, "The Celtic Church-the Lantern of the West-carried on his(Columba's) work and tribal system for nearly 600 years, sending forth missionaries all over Scotland, northern England and western Europe, receiving countless pilgrims, penitents, refugees and criminals...They created works of scholarship such as the Book of Kells...The community consisted of novices, workers and seniors-each having the front of his head shaved, and each with a bee-hive cell of his own near their wooden church. All seems to indicate that St. Columba was truly remarkable man, possessed of many gifts, strong in body, keen in mind and of a deeply mystical spirit. He is credited with visions of angels,

gifts of prophecy and "second sight", yet also had much administrative ability and far-seeing statesmanship. Born in Donegal, Ireland, he was of the distinguished family of Cinel Consill who were descendants of the famous King Niall of the 9 Hostages. His father, Phelin mac Fergus, was chieftain of that district and his mother, Eithne, belonged to the royal house of Leinster. Since his grandmother was sister to Fergus mac Erc who led the Scots to Argyll, Columba was the grand-nephew of the founder of Dalriada. [Thus Columba was related to the MacQuarries as we see later].

The Isle of Iona soon became the chief headquarters of Celtic Christianity. In faith and practice it had many differences with Roman Christianity. Many of these we might consider minor such as the date of Easter and the form in which the monks shaved their heads. Others such as marriage of priests (which the Celts permitted) and the organizational structure were more serious. Gradually over the years the Celtic tradition declined and that of Rome ascended so that by 1200 Roman influence predominated.

D. Merging the Picts & Scots; the Kings of the Alpine Line. The Scots and Picts fought for many generations, but at last became united by marriage, not conquest. King Achaius, of Dalriada married Ferfkusia the royal princess of the Picts. They had a son, Alpin, to whom Fergusia gave her claim to the Pictish throne if her brother Eoghann should die. Alpin became king, but was killed in 836 leaving his son Kenneth, the Dalriadan Crown and also his claim to the Pict throne. Eoghann died in 843 and Kenneth claimed to be King of the Picts. Many Pict nobles were not pleased, but Kenneth put them down by force. The two kingdoms were united with capital first at Dunstaffnage, but this was soon transferred to Scone where Kenneth was finally crowned.

Kenneth mac Alpin's reign over the Picts and Scots ran from 843 to 859. Gradually the union came to be called the Kingdom of Scotland rather than the Kingdoms of Dalriada and of the Picts. Picts became intermixed with Scots, the Pictish tongue gave way to the Gaelic and the Picts gradually lost their identity. Gregg [23] says, "His [Kenneth's] reign marked a very important epoch in the history of Scotland and is the point, according to most historians, where the true annals of [Scotland] should begin.

Scone became the fixed location of the "Lia Fail", or Stone of Destiny upon which all monarchs of Scotland were to be crowned. Fordoun says, "No King of Scotland was ever allowed to reign until he had first...sat upon the Stone of Scone." One legend says the Stone was brought from Tara, the ancient capital of Ireland. Another legend says Jacob pillowed his head on the Stone when he had the dream of angels as recorded in Genesis, Chap 28. The Stone remained at Scone until 1296 when King Edward I carried it to England where it is now incorporated Coronation chair for British sovereigns in Westminster Abbey.

Kenneth MacAlpine died in 859 and was the 1st King of a united Scotland to be buried at Iona (several Dalriadan Kings had been interred there). Over the next 300 years this holy isle became the regular sepulchral place of Scotch Kings. Various records list 48 Scottish Kings, 1 King of France, numerous Irish and Norwegian rulers and many Clan Chiefs.

Alpin and Kenneth founded what became known as the Alpinian line. Douglas writes, "The Alpinian line swayed the Scottish scepter from...834 till the death of Alexander III in 1285, in which time there were 25 Kings of them..." Douglas and most other historians agree that Clan MacQuarrie(as well as the Grants, MacGregors, MacKinnons, Macnabs, MacPhees and MacAulays) are descended from the great Alpine race. [However, there is disagreement as to when and how the connection took place].

[Mairead Farquharson[21] gives one tradition: Kenneth MacAlpine had many sons(some say 7). Each son gave rise to a ancient Clan, in particular son Guaire sired Clan MacQuarrie. Clan MacKinnon comes from Fingon(or Finnon), etc. A MacDonald sennachie in the 12th(or was it 15th) century records a banquet at which the Chiefs were seated "according to their rank and station". Seated 2nd was MacQuarrie, because "MacQuire is an ancient thane" who is praised as "the brave, the fearless, the great feated". If this tradition can be believed, Clan MacQuarrie traces its origin back to the early 900s].

[Alan Macquarrie[35], who as a professional Scottish historian may be a little more conservative, sets Guaire and Finguine (Fingon) as sons of Cormac mac Airbertaich(still a descendant of the Dalriadic rulers) who lived in the late 1200s. He sets the banquet story in the 15th century].

Kenneth mac Alpin was followed on the throne by his brother, Donald II(859-863), his son, Constantine(863-881) and another son Heth(881-882). Many of the following Kings are very dim in history: Donald the Ruddy, Hugh the Fair, Duff the Brown, Kenneth the Grim,etc. It was a bloody time and at least 12 of the 16 Kings after Kenneth were assassinated or killed in battle. Kenneth III(970-994), Constantine(994-995), Kenneth IV(995-1003) and Malcolm II(1003-1033) take us into the 11th century. Malcolm II was followed by Duncan who was killed by MacBeth(more about this later).

E. The Norsemen or Vikings. During the 8th, 9th & 10th centuries the Norsemen went on their fiercest rampages. In addition to home troubles and struggles with the English, Kenneth and his successors were almost constantly on the defensive against these sea marauders. The Norse became masters of the Hebrides, Orkney and Shetland islands; established a stronghold in Dublin, Ireland and made settlements on the coasts of Scotland. Though plunder and cruelty was the aim of many raids, some of the leaders were dissatisfied with conditions at home and tried to set up their own Kingdoms on the Islands.

These Vikings, named from deep bays(viks) that sheltered them on the coasts of Norway and Denmark, were highly virile, intelligent and brave, but also extremely brutal. They were extremely efficient with sword, battle-axe and spear. Contemporary chroniclers described them as scourges of civilization who "...landed wherever they saw the opportunity for spoil...They burned and destroyed what they could not carry away and returned to their

ships loaded with plunder. They slaughtered their captives on the spot or sold them into slavery, but usually kept the fairest women for themselves." No wonder an ancient Prayer Book contained the petition, "From the fury of the Northmen, good Lord, deliver us!" During this time there was a large infiltration of Scandinavian blood, both by intermarriage and without marriage.

Crucial to Viking exploits were their unique galley or long-boat which were swift, flexible and maneuverable. Suitable for short voyages in a sea not exposed to violent storms or tides, some of these vessels succeeded in reaching North America. Each galley carried 40-60 men, about half oarsmen. Built and painted to simulate sea monsters, they struck terror in all who saw them bearing down on the Scottish shore, bent on no good. Monasteries were very hard hit by these raids. Iona was pillaged in the years 795, 801, 802, 806, 870 and 986. One time the Abbot and 86 monks were slain on the pebbly beach still called Martyrs' Bay.

Others besides Abbeys and Churches suffered; raids were made on villages and the countryside. Peasants and gentry as well as monks were slaughtered, their houses burned, their cattle and sheep driven off or slain. [Norse records tell of a raid on Ulva on which the Vikings found nobody there. I've always felt this illustrated that the MacQuarries were intelligent enough to be off visiting friends on Mull that day].

The Scots sometimes allied themselves with the English against the Norse. Long afterwards the English would use these alliances as grounds for claims to the overlordship of Scotland. At other times the Scotch joined the Norsemen against the English. It was an age when everyone was looking out for himself and this only made the bloody turmoil of the times worse.



Church at Kilninian, Ulva Parish church until 1828.